

Lecture # 1

The Hebrew Bible

God's Call and the covenant with Israel

Biblical religion is grounded upon the experience of God's presence which transforms the lives of the individual and the group.

This encounter of people with a reality beyond themselves to which they are related and with which humans can communicate is the essence of biblical religion and constitutes the foundation of Judaism and Christianity.

The Bible tells the nature and course of Israel's relationship to its god YHWH and how he chose a group of tribes to receive his revelation and how they responded to him.

The Covenant tradition

YHWH revealed his name to Moses at the burning bush when he told Moses that he must **free** the people from the Egyptians.

The name revealed was ehiyeh asher eh_yeh, which has been translated I am who I am meaning he is the being who will be eternally present to **his** people.

The decision to enter into the covenant relationship was the great decision of **Israelite** history, resulting in the emergence of a special religious consciousness. For the Jew, the Exodus from Egypt became the central event in religious history.

The covenant is the central conception of the Bible. it formed the framework in which Israel understood its social constitution and historical meaning. At Sinai the clear will of YHWH had been revealed and the people had accepted it.

The Bible presents the nation as founded in a religious event, and its rule as always to be religious law.

the loose tribes were transformed into a people united by shared loyalty to YHWH and the this covenant ordered the political and social realms as well as religious.

Law became absolutely central in the religious life of Israel.

YHWH was the author of a code which governed the entire range of human **life**. His majesty and holiness were embodied in the Law which he had issued.

Therefore it was incumbent upon every Israelite to hear the commandments, to learn them and to perform them. as Deut 6:4-7 says:

Hear O Israel: the Lord our God is one Lord; and you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your might. And these words which I command you this day shall be upon your heart; and you shall teach them diligently to your children.

Because YHWH loved Israel he had chosen Israel to be special and to serve his special mission in the world.

Israel must return his love in every generation by acting to fulfill the sacred obligations of the covenant. This is the clear imperative which issued from the covenant

2

relationship.

Every person of the nation was able to understand and participate in the covenant and thereby share in realizing the divine life.

The conception of a God who acted in history and who participated in an ongoing historical relationship with a community of people broke with the prevailing notions of deity, of nature, and of man in the ancient near east.

the ancient near east viewed the world of nature as being alive with divine forces which were of the same substance and which experienced the same needs as people themselves.

the gods as well as humans were born out of a primeval matter, subject to natural processes and were ultimately subordinate to the laws of nature or fate.

it was because the gods and humans were of the same substance and subject to the same laws that humans could manipulate the gods thru magic and could actually become a god or semigod.

In contrast to the mythological deity, YHWH was conceived by Israel as the absolutely transcendent Lord of the universe whose being was beyond nature and completely other than man. He was totally independent of natural processes and could not be controlled by magic.

The notion was that if Israel fulfilled its side of the covenantal relationship, the progress of history towards its ultimate goal would be advanced. If Israel failed to uphold

3

the covenant stipulations, the divine plan would be frustrated and God's instrument subject to chastisement and punishment.

Biblical history is the record of successive fulfillments and defections, of faithfulness and waywardness, of social peace and social disorder.

This idea of YHWH being the only transcendent Lord did not spring full-blown to Israel. It took many centuries to develop.

Up until the time of Jeremiah and Ezekiel (circa 620-587 B.C.E.) the Israelites were basically monolatrist this

meant that YHWH was seen as the god to whom the Israelites owed allegiance and yet they recognized that other gods existed and made claims on other people.

for example, in Judges the judge Jephthah professed to follow YHWH but told the Moabites to possess the land which Chemosh their god gave them.

At the time of Moses it was believed that YHWH had chosen Israel but he proved he was stronger than other gods by beating them thru the Israelite army .

The land was an important part of the covenant because one's god needed a place to dwell .

Thus Cyrus the Persian sent the Jews home in 538 B.C.E. because he believed that their god had been away from his land long enough .

by this time, the Jews had come to understand God as one and over all .

4

Ezekial's vision of the Merkavah the chariot throne , showed that God was not tied to Jerusalem as the throne lifted from the temple in Jerusalem and flew to Babylon . This was a big step in understanding the nature of God .

kings and prophets

under Joshua the Israelites conquered the land of Canaan

around 1200 B. they renewed the covenant at Shechem (Josh .
24:22-24) and formed a confederacy based upon the covenant
agreement.

there were those that had never left Canaan when Jacob's
tribes went to Egypt who renewed the covenant with the
conquerors.

the judges of the O. T. were believed to be graced with
the spirit of YHWH and in a holy war carried the tribes to
victory.

the ideal form of Israelite communal life was most
closely realized during this period of the judges. The
tribes were linked with common faith and worship and
believed themselves to be protected by YHWH's spirit.

however, tension between the ideal and the real were ever
present, and resistance to God's commands were constant.

Monarchy

the strain between the divine and human order became most
intense when the question of monarchy arose, for the
institution of monarchy meant that a permanent human ruler

was placed over the people of God and secular interests were
asserted over the moral and religious ideals of the Yahwist

order.

the institution of the monarchy threatened the foundations of covenant society as it says in I Sam 8:7:

And the Lord said to Samuel, "Harken to the voice of the people in all that they say to you for they have not rejected you, but they have rejected me from being king over them.

Saul was first anointed as king in about 1020 B.C. a tribal leader not followed by all.

He was

David was made king in 1000 B.C. and from then on considered the prototype of all great kings. He brought the Israelites to the largest empire they have ever known.

The second type of covenant found in the Heb. Scrip. is with David. This is found in II Sam. 7 and Psalm 89 as well

YHWH swears his allegiance to as with Abraham in Gen. 12. The concept here is not a covenant of law but of grace.

David (and Abraham) regardless of what they have done only their allegiance.

This understanding of the covenant is found in many of the prophets and also in the New Test thru Jesus and Paul.

although kingship was integrated into the covenant the

basic tension between the divine and human rule was never

Overcome .

the history of Israel under the kings was plagued by

6

continual crisis both internally and externally .

Political maneuvering in the international arena brought
military defeat and finally downfall to Northern Israel in
722 and to Judah in 586.

the prophets

The prophets were YHWH's representatives sent to try to
call the people back to the covenant .

they battled against syncretism with foreign religions,
economic oppression, social **injustice**, and international
political involvement .

the prophets called for inner change, for a revival of
the covenant, and a regeneration of religious life.

Elijah is a semi-legendary prophet of the 9th cent. b.

he is the prototype of the prophet.

Most of the first book

of Kings is involved with him waging war to win back the
alliance of Israel to YHWH

However, Israel persisted in its defection, the decline
in religious life was unabated, despite the mighty effort of
the prophets to return Israel

Israel to itself and thus save the

nation from disaster.

Amos an 8th cent. prophet, condemned this moral degeneration
most thoroughly, finding Israel guilty of all manner of
ethical behaviour.

The concept of Justice and the demand of YHWH for

7

adherence to ethical norms came from Amos.

Amos proclaimed that according to the religion of YHWH
ethics was more significant than than cult and that moral
behavior would determine the national fate of Israel.

this same proclamation was echoed by the later prophets
such as the first Isaiah and Hosea.

to Isaiah the worst of Israel's sins was pride, the

self-assertion and self-confidence of man which inevitably led to rebellion against God.

he proclaimed that history was controlled by YHWH and that human force did not determine its order. Trust in self was idolatry, a sin which Israel committed constantly. punishment would come.

and

According to the prophets, knowledge of God and knowledge of the covenant were absolutely essential if Israel were to realize its true national destiny, and yet it was just this knowledge which had been lost.

The great 8th cent northern prophet, Hosea believed and preached that life **without** God had led to life without righteousness, life without truth, and life without mercy.

to Hosea, loss of self implied loss of the relationship with YHWH and it was this sin of which Israel was guilty.

The Northern Kingdom of Hebrew tribes (10 of them) was finally defeated by Assyria in 722 B.

the land was ruined, towns destroyed, and the population exiled.

throughout

that cent and the next Judah was threatened

in the eyes of the prophets the wrath of YHWH had been

brought to the people and only genuine repentance could

avoid the same fate.

the safety and prosperity of Israel depended upon the

protection of YHWH alone, and this was granted only when the

moral conditions of the covenant had been fulfilled.

prophets speaking at the height of the national danger

called Judah to repent to avoid catastrophe saying it

not YHWH who had failed **but** the people.

as the moral crises deepened the prophets began looking

at the future rather than the present.

belief was that YHWH's plan for history was not

permanently overthrown nor his promises void.

the prophets perceived meaning **in** this condition and

projected new hopes for a renewed covenant people.

Jeremiah was the solitary defender of the covenant from

617-586

in 622 a scroll was found in the temple and brought to

the king, Josiah. He called **for** the Passover feast to be

celebrated, which it had not been in many years.

However,

Jeremiah could see that the people were not
changing within so he warned the king and the people of the

9

doom to come promising hope for the righteous few who would survive the
holocaust.

Of all the prophets, the fate of Jeremiah was the most tragic. He
prayed for the people tried to turn them from; destruction and was
ignored. He was treated badly and in Jer chap 15 he begins to curse the
day he was born for he is
miserable.

doom.

Jeremiah predicted defeat upon the erring nation, but not complete

There would also be salvation

The hope of salvation was tied to the entire prophetic theodicy, which
had to do with the vindication of the divine attributes

particularity

holiness and justice, in regard to the existence of physical and moral
evil. It attempted to make sense of the religious crisis and give
meaning to the severe difficulties which the covenant people was to
undergo.